Methodology

1. Overview

The forecasting task is to predict, at every hour, the all-sky surface shortwave downward irradiance (ALLSKY_SFC_SW_DWN, W/m²) for each of the following 24 hours at five sites in Türkiye. Point forecasts are produced by a Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) network, and predictive uncertainty is quantified by combining a moving-block bootstrap ensemble with Monte Carlo (MC) Dropout. The combination follows the hybrid ensemble–dropout scheme of Rajaperumal and Chinnappan, adapted in three respects: an LSTM replaces their physics-constrained feed-forward backbone, irradiance replaces photovoltaic power as the target, and the bootstrap resamples contiguous blocks of the training series rather than individual observations.

The procedure consists of the following stages, each described below. The terms *period*, *window*, *block*, *replicate* and *pass* have precise meanings, defined in Section 2.

1. Split the record chronologically into a training, a validation and a test period, and standardise every variable using the training period only.
2. Cut each site's series into overlapping windows of 48 hours: 24 input hours followed by the 24 hours to be forecast.
3. Build B bootstrap replicates of the training windows by drawing blocks of consecutive windows with replacement.
4. Train one LSTM on each replicate, with dropout.
5. Run every trained network M times on each test window with dropout kept active (MC Dropout), giving $B \times M$ forecasts per window.
6. Pool these forecasts into a predictive distribution, from which the point forecast, the variance decomposition and the 95% prediction interval are derived.
7. Set forecasts to zero when the sun is below the horizon.
8. Optionally recalibrate the interval width by split-conformal prediction.
9. Evaluate on the test period.

2. Terminology: hours, periods, windows, blocks, replicates and passes

The bootstrap and MC Dropout operate on different objects, and the parameters that control them are easy to confuse. In particular, the 24-hour input length of a window and the 168-window length of a bootstrap block are unrelated settings, and MC Dropout involves neither blocks nor resampling.

2.1 Definitions

Table 1. Terms used throughout, from the smallest unit to the largest. Counts are per site unless stated otherwise.

Term	Definition	Size in this study	Used by
Hour	One hourly record of one site, in local solar time	61,368 per site	All stages
Period	One of three consecutive, non-overlapping date ranges: training, validation, test	45,412 / 6,750 / 9,206 hours	All stages

Term	Definition	Size in this study	Used by
Window	48 consecutive hours of one site: 24 input hours, then 24 target hours	45,365 / 6,703 / 9,159 windows	Training and prediction
Forecast origin	The last input hour of a window, i.e. the hour at which the forecast is issued	One per window	–
Horizon step h	One of the 24 target hours of a window, $h = 1$ being the hour after the origin	24 per window	Evaluation
Element	One window at one horizon step; the unit every metric is averaged over	219,816 test elements	Evaluation
Block	ℓ consecutive training windows of one site	ℓ = 168 windows	Bootstrap only
Replicate	A resampled copy of the training windows, assembled from blocks	$B = 8$	Bootstrap only
Network	One LSTM, trained on one replicate	$B = 8$	–
Pass	One forward run of a network on a window with a fresh random dropout mask	$M = 100$ per network	MC Dropout only

2.2 Periods

Each site's hourly series is cut at two dates that are the same for all sites:

```
 training period (74%)            validation period (11%)      test period (15%)
|--------------------------------|----------------------------|-------------------------|
30 Jun 2019 00:00    3 Sep 2024 03:00             11 Jun 2025 09:00        29 Jun 2026 23:00
      45,412 hours                      6,750 hours                   9,206 hours
```

The training period is used to fit the standardisation, to build the bootstrap replicates and to train the networks. The validation period is used for early stopping, learning-rate scheduling and, when used, conformal recalibration. The test period is used only for evaluation.

2.3 Windows

A window is the unit the network sees: the 24 most recent hours as input, and the following 24 hours as the target.

```
hour:     t−23  t−22  ...  t−1   t   | t+1   t+2   ...  t+24
          <------ 24 input hours ----> <---- 24 target hours ---->
                                      ^
                              forecast origin t
```

Windows are taken at every hour (stride 1), so consecutive windows overlap by 47 of their 48 hours:

```
window k      [ 24 in  | 24 out ]
window k+1     [ 24 in  | 24 out ]
window k+2      [ 24 in  | 24 out ]
                ...
```

A window is kept only if all 48 of its hours lie inside one period; the 47 windows per site that would straddle each period boundary are discarded. This is why a period of H hours yields $H - 47$ windows (for example 45,412 − 47 = 45,365 training windows per site). Windows never mix two sites. The temporal order of

the 48 hours inside a window is always preserved, by construction, whatever happens to the window afterwards.

2.4 Blocks and replicates (bootstrap only)

The bootstrap does not cut the series again and does not create new windows. It takes the 45,365 training windows of one site, in time order, and draws *blocks* of $\ell = 168$ consecutive windows from them:

```
training windows of one site, in time order:   w1  w2  w3  ...  w45365

one block starting at w_j:   w_j, w_j+1, ..., w_j+167
   = 168 forecast origins spanning 7 days (215 hours of data, inputs and targets included)

one replicate for this site: [block at w_9120][block at w_301][block at w_40007] ...
   = 271 randomly placed blocks, joined and cut to exactly 45,365 windows
```

The same is done independently for the other four sites, and the five resampled sets are pooled into one replicate. Repeating this $B = 8$ times gives eight replicates, and one network is trained on each.

What the blocks accomplish needs stating precisely. Windows inside a replicate are shuffled into mini-batches during training, and the network carries no state from one window to the next, so the order in which blocks are joined plays no role. What the blocks control is *which* windows enter a replicate, and how often: neighbouring windows, which share most of their hours and the same weather, are included or left out together, a week at a time. A replicate is therefore a resampling of weeks of weather rather than of isolated hours, which is the dependence an independent (window-by-window) bootstrap would ignore. A replicate contains about 61–65% of the distinct training windows, some of them several times over.

2.5 Passes (MC Dropout only)

MC Dropout acts after training, on one window at a time. A trained network is run $M = 100$ times on the same test window, each time with a new random dropout mask, giving 100 slightly different 24-hour forecasts. No periods, blocks or replicates are involved at this step: the windows are the ordinary test windows, used once each and in no particular order. With $B = 8$ networks, every test window receives $8 \times 100 = 800$ forecasts.

2.6 How the pieces combine

```
training windows (5 sites)
   |-- bootstrap with blocks --> replicate 1 --> train --> network 1 --+
   |-- bootstrap with blocks --> replicate 2 --> train --> network 2 --+
   |   ...                                                             |
   '-- bootstrap with blocks --> replicate 8 --> train --> network 8 --+
                                                                       |
test window --> 100 dropout passes through each of the 8 networks <----+
           --> 800 forecasts of the next 24 hours
           --> mean, variance decomposition, 95% interval
```

3. Problem formulation

Let $s \in \{1, \ldots, 5\}$ index the site and t the hour, expressed in each site's local solar time. Let $\mathbf{x}_{s,t} \in \mathbb{R}^{13}$ be the standardised feature vector of site s at hour t (Section 4) and $y_{s,t}$ the observed irradiance. The input of the window with origin t is

$$X_{s,t} = (\boldsymbol{x}_{s,t-23}, \ldots, \boldsymbol{x}_{s,t}),$$

and its target is the irradiance over the following 24 hours,

$$y_{s,t} = (y_{s,t+1}, \ldots, y_{s,t+24}).$$

The model maps the window and the site identity to all 24 values at once (direct multi-output forecasting):

$$\hat{y}_{s,t} = f_\theta(X_{s,t}, s) \in \mathbb{R}^{24}. \tag{1}$$

Each horizon step $h = 1, \ldots, 24$ is therefore a separate output of the same network rather than the result of feeding earlier predictions back as inputs. Only observed quantities enter the window; no numerical weather prediction or other forecast of the meteorological variables is used, so the inputs are all available at the time the forecast is issued.

A single model is trained on all five sites jointly. Site identity enters only through a learned embedding (Section 6), so information can be shared across climates while the network can still represent site-specific behaviour.

4. Input variables

Table 2 lists the 13 model inputs. The target's own history is included as an input, so the model is autoregressive in irradiance. Wind direction is encoded by its sine and cosine to remove the discontinuity at 0°/360°, and the hour of day and day of year are encoded the same way. Solar geometry (solar elevation and top-of-atmosphere irradiance) is computed from the site coordinates and the timestamp but is used only to define daylight (Section 9); it is not a model input, because the cyclical time encodings already carry that information.

Table 2. Model inputs.

Variable	Description	Unit
ALLSKY_SFC_SW_DWN	All-sky surface shortwave downward irradiance (lagged target)	W/m²
T2M	Air temperature at 2 m	°C
RH2M	Relative humidity at 2 m	%
T2MDEW	Dew/frost point at 2 m	°C
PS	Surface pressure	kPa
WS2M	Wind speed at 2 m	m/s
PRECTOTCORR	Bias-corrected precipitation	mm/h
WD2M (sin, cos)	Wind direction at 2 m, sine and cosine	–
Hour of day (sin, cos)	2π · hour / 24	–
Day of year (sin, cos)	2π · day of year / 365.25	–

5. Data partitioning, standardisation and windowing

The record (30 June 2019 00:00 – 29 June 2026 23:00, 61,368 hours per site) is divided into the three periods of Section 2.2, in proportions 74% / 11% / 15%. The boundaries are computed once and are identical at every site. The test period spans 384 days and covers all four seasons; the validation period contains no July or August and only the first eleven days of June.

Every variable, the target included, is standardised to zero mean and unit variance, with means and standard deviations estimated from the training period only and then applied unchanged to the validation and test periods. For the target these are $\bar{y}$ = 198.5 W/m² and s_y = 279.7 W/m². Networks are trained on the standardised target, and their forecasts are transformed back to W/m² before evaluation.

Windows are built as described in Section 2.3. Across the five sites this gives 226,825 training, 33,515 validation and 45,795 test windows.

6. Network architecture

The network has three parts.

- **Site embedding.** Each site is mapped to a learned 4-dimensional vector, which is concatenated to the feature vector at every hour of the window, giving 17 inputs per hour.
- **Recurrent encoder.** Two stacked LSTM layers with 64 hidden units each read the 24 input hours in order. Dropout (rate p = 0.3) is applied between the two layers, and again to the hidden state of the second layer at the last input hour, which summarises the window.
- **Output head.** A fully connected layer with 32 units and ReLU activation, followed by dropout (p = 0.3) and a linear layer with 24 outputs, one per horizon step.

The network has 57,420 trainable parameters. It contains no batch normalisation, because MC Dropout runs the network in training mode at prediction time, where batch normalisation would use the statistics of the prediction batch rather than fixed ones. Dropout is therefore the only source of randomness at prediction time.

7. Training

Each network is trained on its replicate by minimising, over mini-batches of N windows, the mean squared error on the standardised target plus a penalty on negative standardised forecasts:

$$\mathcal{L}(\theta) = (1/24N)\, \Sigma_i \Sigma_h\, (\tilde{z}_{i,h} - z_{i,h})^2 + \lambda\, (1/24N)\, \Sigma_i \Sigma_h\, max(0, -\tilde{z}_{i,h})^2, \quad (2)$$

where $z = (y - \bar{y})/s_y$ is the standardised observation, $\tilde{z}$ the standardised forecast, and λ = 0.1. The squared error targets the conditional mean, so the point forecast is an estimate of expected irradiance.

The penalty is intended to discourage physically impossible negative irradiance. Because it is evaluated on the standardised scale, however, it acts on forecasts below the training-period mean, $\hat{y} < \bar{y}$ = 198.5 W/m², rather than below 0 W/m². This covers about 66% of training hours, including every night hour, so the penalty pulls low forecasts upward, towards the mean. At night the resulting bias is removed by the constraint of Section 9; on low-irradiance daylight hours (early morning, late afternoon, overcast conditions) it is not. The physically intended form would be $\max(0, -(\tilde{z} + \bar{y}/s_y))^2$, which is zero for every non-negative forecast. **[Known issue: the implemented form is the one in Eq. 2; correcting it requires retraining every network.]**

Optimisation uses Adam with an initial learning rate of 10^{-3} and mini-batches of 128 windows, reshuffled every epoch. After each epoch the loss of Eq. 2, penalty included, is computed on the validation windows with dropout disabled. The learning rate is halved when this validation loss has not improved for 7 epochs. Training stops when it has not improved for 10 epochs, or after 100 epochs, and the weights from the epoch with the lowest validation loss are kept. Every network uses the same, unresampled validation windows.

8. Uncertainty quantification

8.1 Moving-block bootstrap

Meteorological and irradiance series are strongly autocorrelated, so resampling windows independently would treat near-identical neighbouring windows as independent evidence. A moving-block bootstrap is used instead (Section 2.4). For site s with n_s chronologically ordered training windows and block length ℓ, $\lceil n_s/\ell \rceil$ block start positions are drawn uniformly and with replacement from $\{1, \ldots, n_s - \ell + 1\}$. The blocks of ℓ consecutive windows are joined and cut to exactly n_s windows. This is repeated for every site, and the five resampled sets are pooled into one replicate:

$$\mathcal{D}^{(1)}, \mathcal{D}^{(2)}, \ldots, \mathcal{D}^{(B)}. \tag{3}$$

With n_s = 45,365 and ℓ = 168, each site contributes 271 blocks per replicate. Resampling site by site keeps the number of windows per site identical in every replicate, so no replicate is dominated by one climate. Each window carries its own inputs and targets, so resampling cannot pair an input with the wrong target. The block length of 168 windows (one week of forecast origins) is chosen to span the diurnal cycle and the multi-day lifetime of synoptic weather systems. As in any moving-block bootstrap, windows within $\ell - 1$ of either end of a site's training series can be drawn by fewer block positions and so appear less often.

Only training windows are resampled. Validation windows are the same for every replicate and are used only for early stopping and learning-rate scheduling; test windows take no part in training or resampling.

[To be decided: whether to run a block-length sensitivity analysis (ℓ = 24, 72 and 168 windows); it has not been run.]

8.2 Monte Carlo Dropout

One network f_{θ_b} is trained on each replicate $\mathcal{D}^{(b)}$, starting from a different random initialisation. During training, dropout acts as a regulariser. At prediction time it is kept active, so each forward pass applies a fresh random dropout mask $\mathbf{z}_{b,m}$, drawn independently for every window. With M passes per network, every input window receives $B \times M$ stochastic forecasts (Section 2.5):

$$\hat{y}^{(b,m)} = f_{\theta_b}(X, s; \mathbf{z}_{b,m}), \quad b = 1, \ldots, B, \; m = 1, \ldots, M. \tag{4}$$

This study uses B = 8 and M = 100, giving 800 forecasts for every window and horizon step. All quantities below are computed separately for each element, i.e. for each window and horizon step.

8.3 Predictive mean and variance decomposition

The point forecast is the mean over all $B \times M$ forecasts:

$$\hat{\mu} = (1/BM) \, \Sigma_{b=1}^{B} \, \Sigma_{m=1}^{M} \, \hat{y}^{(b,m)}. \tag{5}$$

The spread of the pooled forecasts has two sources. Writing the mean of network b as

$$\hat{\mu}_b = (1/M)\,\Sigma_{m=1}^{M}\,\hat{y}^{(b,m)}, \tag{6}$$

the variability within each network due to dropout is

$$\sigma^2_{MC} = (1/B)\,\Sigma_{b=1}^{B}\,(1/M)\,\Sigma_{m=1}^{M}\,(\hat{y}^{(b,m)} - \hat{\mu}_b)^2, \tag{7}$$

and the variability between networks due to the bootstrap replicates is

$$\sigma^2_{boot} = (1/B)\,\Sigma_{b=1}^{B}\,(\hat{\mu}_b - \hat{\mu})^2. \tag{8}$$

By the law of total variance, their sum is exactly the variance of the pooled forecasts:

$$\sigma^2_{epi} = \sigma^2_{MC} + \sigma^2_{boot} = (1/BM)\,\Sigma_b\,\Sigma_m\,(\hat{y}^{(b,m)} - \hat{\mu})^2. \tag{9}$$

Both components describe uncertainty about the model, that is, epistemic uncertainty: how much the conditional-mean forecast would change with different training data (σ^2_{boot}) and under the approximate posterior over network weights that MC Dropout represents (σ^2_{MC}). Reporting the two separately shows how much each part of the ensemble contributes. **[Known issue: the pipeline currently stores only the total, σ_{epi}; the two components require a small change to be reported.]**

8.4 Prediction interval

The nominal 95% prediction interval is given by the empirical 2.5th and 97.5th percentiles of the $B \times M$ pooled forecasts:

$$PI_{95} = [Q_{0.025}(\{\hat{y}^{(b,m)}\}),\, Q_{0.975}(\{\hat{y}^{(b,m)}\})]. \tag{10}$$

Because the interval is taken from the pooled sample rather than from a Gaussian assumption, it can be asymmetric, which arises naturally when the networks disagree in one direction.

8.5 Aleatoric uncertainty and interval recalibration

Every network outputs a single value per horizon step, so the pooled forecasts describe uncertainty about the conditional mean only. They contain no term for the variability of the observation around that mean (aleatoric uncertainty), which in irradiance is dominated by cloud processes that a 24-hour history cannot resolve. The pooled interval is therefore expected to cover fewer than 95% of observations.

This can be corrected by split-conformal recalibration on the validation period. The pooled forecasts for each element are rescaled about their own mean,

$$\hat{y}^{(b,m)} \to \hat{\mu} + k\,(\hat{y}^{(b,m)} - \hat{\mu}), \tag{11}$$

so the point forecast, and hence every point-accuracy metric, is unchanged, while the interval endpoints and the whole predictive distribution scale together. To estimate k, every network is also run M times on each validation window, exactly as on the test windows. For each validation element with observation y and interval $[L, U]$, the conformity score is the smallest factor that would have covered it:

$$r = (y - \hat{\mu}) / (U - \hat{\mu}) \text{ if } y \geq \hat{\mu}, \quad r = (\hat{\mu} - y) / (\hat{\mu} - L) \text{ otherwise.} \tag{12}$$

Given n scores, k is the $\lceil (n+1)(1-\alpha) \rceil$-th smallest, with $\alpha = 0.05$. Factors are estimated separately for each cell of a grid defined by **[to be decided: the grid, e.g. site × season]**; cells with fewer than 200 usable scores fall back to the pooled factor. Night-time elements, where forecast and observation are both

zero, carry no information about the interval width and are excluded from calibration. The reference run reported here uses no recalibration.

Two limitations follow from the data. First, the validation period also serves for early stopping, so the calibration data are not entirely independent of training decisions; the dependence is weak, because early stopping selects only the epoch. Second, the validation period contains no July or August and only the first eleven days of June, so the summer factors are extrapolated from the other months.

9. Physical constraint at night

Daylight is defined geometrically: an hour is a daylight hour if the apparent solar elevation at the midpoint of the hour, computed from the site coordinates and the timestamp, is above zero. When the sun is below the horizon, irradiance is physically zero. For every such element, all $B \times M$ forecasts are set to zero, so the point forecast and both interval endpoints are zero. The constraint uses only site and time, so it is available when the forecast is issued, and it is applied identically to every model.

10. Evaluation

10.1 Evaluation subsets

All metrics are computed on the test period, over every test window and all 24 horizon steps, and reported for two subsets: all hours, and daylight hours only (solar elevation > 0). About half of all elements are night hours whose observation and (constrained) forecast are both exactly zero. These lower RMSE and MAE, inflate R^2 because the day–night cycle dominates the total variance, and are covered by every interval by construction. **Daylight metrics are therefore the headline results**; all-hours metrics are given for completeness.

Because test windows overlap, each test hour appears as a target in up to 24 windows, once at each horizon step. Metrics are averages over elements, so every hour is counted once per horizon step at which it is forecast.

Results are reported pooled over the five sites, for each site, pooled over the four sites other than Rize (which forms a distinct radiative regime), and for each horizon step.

10.2 Point-forecast metrics

With $\hat{\mu}_i$ the point forecast and y_i the observation over the N elements of a subset:

$$RMSE = \sqrt{[(1/N)\,\Sigma_i\,(\hat{\mu}_i - y_i)^2]},\quad MAE = (1/N)\,\Sigma_i\,|\hat{\mu}_i - y_i|,\quad R^2 = 1 - \Sigma_i(y_i - \hat{\mu}_i)^2 \,/\, \Sigma_i(y_i - \bar{y}_{sub})^2, \tag{13}$$

where $\bar{y}_{sub}$ is the mean observation of the subset.

10.3 Probabilistic metrics

With $[L_i, U_i]$ the 95% interval and $\mu = 0.95$ the nominal coverage:

- **Coverage probability**, $CP = (1/N)\,\Sigma_i\,\mathbb{1}(L_i \le y_i \le U_i)$;
- **Reliability**, $|CP - \mu|$;
- **Mean prediction interval width**, $MPIW = (1/N)\,\Sigma_i\,(U_i - L_i)$, in W/m²;
- **Prediction interval normalised width**, PINW = MPIW / (max y − min y), with the range taken over the subset;

- **Coverage width-based criterion**, CWC = PINW · [1 + γ exp(−η (CP − μ))], with γ = 1 if CP < μ and 0 otherwise, and η = 50;
- **Continuous ranked probability score**, estimated from the $S = B \times M$ pooled forecasts as

$$CRPS = (1/N)\,\Sigma_i\,[\,(1/S)\,\Sigma_j\,|\hat{y}_i^{(j)} - y_i| - (1/2S^2)\,\Sigma_j\,\Sigma_{j'}\,|\hat{y}_i^{(j)} - \hat{y}_i^{(j')}|\,], \tag{14}$$

in W/m². CRPS rewards calibration and sharpness together and reduces to MAE for a deterministic forecast, which makes it directly comparable with the reference forecasts below.

A run is judged first on whether daylight CP is close to 0.95, then on interval sharpness (PINW, CWC) and CRPS, alongside the point metrics.

10.4 Reference forecasts

Two reference forecasts are evaluated on exactly the same test windows and subsets:

- **Climatology**: the mean irradiance of the same site, calendar month and hour of day over the training period;
- **Persistence**: the observed irradiance at the same site and hour on the previous day.

A model is considered informative only if it beats climatology on daylight RMSE and R^2 and persistence on daylight MAE, the strongest reference on each measure.

11. Reproducibility

Each experiment is fully specified by a configuration file and a master random seed. The resampling generator is seeded from the master seed, and network b is initialised from seed + b, so the replicates and their initialisations are reproducible. Results are reproducible on the same hardware backend; different backends do not agree bit for bit. The reference run was trained in PyTorch on an Apple-silicon GPU (MPS backend).